

BIOL 480: Applications of Biotechnology

Fall 2026

Neil R. Voss

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BIOL 480 - Applications of Biotechnology

Applications of Biotechnology examines research, medical, environmental, and industrial uses of biotechnology through current literature, discussion, presentations, and applied projects.

Course at a glance

Course summary	Fall 2026
Sections	BIOL 480-10 and BIOL 480-24
Format	Hybrid and videoconferenced
Meeting	Thursday, 6:00-9:00 p.m.
Locations	WB 416, Chicago; SCH 614, Schaumburg
Session	August 31-December 19, 2026
Credit hours	3.0

Meetings and instructor

Section information

Field	BIOL 480-10	BIOL 480-24
CRN	14705	11602
Cross-listed with	BIOL 480-24	BIOL 480-10
Meeting	Thursday, 6:00-9:00 p.m.	Thursday, 6:00-9:00 p.m.
Location	WB 416, Chicago campus	SCH 614, Schaumburg campus
Format	Hybrid; videoconferenced	Hybrid; videoconferenced
Credit hours	3.0	3.0
Session dates	August 31-December 19, 2026	August 31-December 19, 2026
Prerequisites	None	None

Catalog description

Research, medical, environmental, and industrial uses of biotechnology. Lectures by biotechnology faculty and industrial researchers address current and future trends in the field.

Instructor information

Field	Information
Instructor	Associate Professor Neil R. Voss
Experience	Instructor at Roosevelt since Fall 2010
Office locations	SCH 600E, Schaumburg campus; secure Zoom link in Blackboard
Course community	Secure invitation link in Blackboard
Email	nvoss@roosevelt.edu
Telephone	(847) 619-7966 (SCH); <i>voice message only</i>
Mailbox	SCH 600
Response time	I will have read your email within 24 hours. I will respond within two business days; I like to think about any responses I make.
Office hours	Thursday, 12:30-1:30 p.m.; Wednesday, 2:30-3:30 p.m.; also available by appointment

Field	Information
University important dates	Link to Google Sheet

Learning Objectives, Outcomes, and Goals

Roosevelt learning goals

- Effective communication.
- Knowledge of discipline-focused content.
- Awareness of social justice and engagement in civic life.

Learning Objectives

Students completing this course will have achieved:

- Experience using discussion, presentations, current literature, and project work to connect scientific discovery with biotechnology practice and innovation.

Course Learning Outcomes

Students completing this course will be able to:

1. Explain major concepts, methods, and tools used in biotechnology.
2. Discuss current biotechnology developments and evaluate their scientific basis.
3. Compare medical, agricultural, environmental, and industrial applications.
4. Analyze biotechnology issues from scientific, ethical, regulatory, and economic perspectives.
5. Use primary literature to evaluate claims and support decisions.
6. Communicate biotechnology concepts in academic and applied settings.
7. Apply biotechnology knowledge to research, product-development, or policy problems.
8. Work collaboratively to develop and defend a biotechnology proposal.

Learning Goals

Overall, this course aims to accomplish:

- Examination of research, medical, environmental, and industrial uses of biotechnology through current literature, discussion, presentations, and applied projects.

Coursework and grades

Course point plan

Assessment	Possible points	Approximate share
Individual biotechnology project	88	24%
Group biotechnology project	91	25%
In-class discussion	100	28%
Talking-point assignments	72	20%
Course onboarding and response forms	11	3%
Total	362	100%

Extra-credit opportunities do not increase the denominator used to calculate the final percentage.

Letter-grade scale

Percentage	Grade
92.0% and above	A
90.0-91.9%	A-
88.0-89.9%	B+
82.0-87.9%	B
80.0-81.9%	B-
78.0-79.9%	C+
72.0-77.9%	C
70.0-71.9%	C-
68.0-69.9%	D+
62.0-67.9%	D
60.0-61.9%	D-
Below 60.0%	F

Percentages are rounded to one decimal place when the final course grade is calculated.
Blackboard is the authoritative record for submissions, scores, and feedback.

Dates and topics

Week	Date	Topic	Project or work due
1	Thu, Sep 3	Course introduction; defining biotechnology	Course orientation
2	Thu, Sep 10	Biotechnology basics and the central dogma	Talking point 1
3	Thu, Sep 17	DNA and genomics biotechnology	Project ideas
4	Thu, Sep 24	Protein biotechnology	Student profile
5	Thu, Oct 1	Biotechnology case-study discussion	Project response
6	Thu, Oct 8	Environmental and synthetic biotechnology	Project selection
7	Thu, Oct 15	Biotechnology news and individual project workshop	Talking point 4
8	Thu, Oct 22	Individual project presentations, part 1	Slides and executive summary
9	Thu, Oct 29	Individual project presentations, part 2	Milestones
10	Thu, Nov 5	Biotechnology film and analysis	Response form
11	Thu, Nov 12	Medicinal biotechnology	Group formation
12	Thu, Nov 19	Regulation of biotechnology	Group project selection
-	Thu, Nov 26	Thanksgiving; no class	-
13	Thu, Dec 3	Bioethics in biotechnology	Group vision report
14	Thu, Dec 10	Group presentations, part 1	Presentation materials
15	Thu, Dec 17	Group presentations, part 2	Business plan

The schedule may change in response to university decisions, invited-speaker availability, class progress, or student learning needs. Blackboard contains the current assignment deadlines.

Dr. Voss course policies

These are Dr. Voss's shared policies for every Fall 2026 course on this site. Each course links to this same policy set, and every complete syllabus download includes each topic once.

Overview

Contacting the instructor

See [Instructor information](#) for my current email address, telephone, office locations, office hours, response time, and the location of the secure course-community invitation.

Use the course community as your first mode of contact. Post general questions in the class channel so everyone benefits; send a direct message for private matters. Institutional email is also appropriate for course matters, but please do not use my Gmail account. If I do not respond within the stated response time, please send a follow-up message.

Phone contact is limited. I generally do not answer unknown numbers, the office phone does not receive texts, and voicemail transcription may garble details. Use the course community or institutional email for the quickest, clearest response. If scheduled office hours do not work, send two or three possible meeting times and I will try to schedule one.

Urgent responses

In academia, unlike medical emergencies or other crises, most situations do not require immediate attention, even those that may seem urgent. If you face challenges, such as a technical issue during an exam, here's how to handle it:

- **Document the Problem:** If you encounter difficulties with Blackboard, take screenshots and note any error messages.
- **Contact Me:** Send a direct message through the course community or an institutional email explaining the issue.
- **Await My Response:** I will address the problem during normal working hours. My methods for resolving the issue, such as granting time extensions or resets, are designed to ensure that you are not disadvantaged. **Rest assured, I will assist you as soon as I'm available.**

Online quiz and exam reset policy

I make it a point to remind students of this policy during lecture before each exam. If you experience internet issues, technical difficulties, accidentally open the exam, or face other non-academic distractions during a quiz or exam, follow these steps:

1. **Don't Panic:** Stay calm and do not rush.
2. **Stop and Exit:** Close the quiz or exam without viewing additional questions.
3. **Contact Me Immediately:** Preferably via Discord, but email is also fine. Do not expect an immediate response, I will contact you when I am available.

How I Handle Different Situations

1. **Less than 10% of the questions:** I can reset the quiz or exam for a fresh start.
2. **Between 10% and 90% of the questions:** I will likely create a custom quiz or exam covering only the questions you haven't seen.
3. **100% of the questions (rushed to complete):** I can offer a second attempt, but your final score will be the average of both attempts.

Changes to syllabi

As the instructor, I reserve the right to modify any aspect of the course, including assignments and due dates, to better address the students' needs and interests. Any changes to the syllabus will be communicated to students via RU email and Blackboard and will also be announced in class. It is your responsibility to attend class and regularly check your RU email and Blackboard for updates or modifications.

Online community

- **Zoom:** We will be participating in lectures via Zoom Video Conferencing software.
- **Blackboard:** Scores and assignments will be posted on Blackboard.
- **Google Forms:** Assignments will be completed using Google Forms; this requires a Gmail account.
- **Google Slides:** Classroom presentations will be made using Google Slides; this requires a Gmail account.
- **Discord:** Course communication will take place over a Discord server; you will need to sign up.

Course modalities

Face-to-face

Face-to-face courses will meet according to the scheduled time in the Wabash or Auditorium Buildings in downtown Chicago, or on the Roosevelt campus in Schaumburg. Always inform your professor when you cannot attend a class session. Please allow enough time to get to your courses via the elevator or stairs in the Wabash and Auditorium buildings. Some face-to-face classes may include an online Zoom component instead of meeting in person on all scheduled dates. To confirm when Zoom meetings occur, you must check the course syllabus.

Online

Online courses are web-based, run on Blackboard, and are asynchronous. There are no set or required meeting days or times. Asynchronous learning occurs through Blackboard without real-

time interaction. Asynchronous methods may include discussion boards, readings, viewing videos, email exchanges, or assignments. As with all classes, there are deadlines for assignments.

Hybrid, including Zoom remote

Hybrid courses include a combination of online and in-person activities. In a hybrid learning environment, the online and in-person components of the course should integrate in a cohesive manner. The activities completed online complement those undertaken in the classroom. It is important that students know when classes will meet in person and when the content will be delivered online. The hybrid modality is good for flipping the classroom, where content is delivered online and discussion or hands-on engaging activities take place in the classroom.

Statement of Roosevelt-owned land

Roosevelt University is positioned on the traditional, unceded homelands of the Council of the Three Fires: the Ojibwe, Odawa, and Potawatomi Nations. Many other tribes such as the Miami, Ho-Chunk, Menominee, Sac, and Fox also called this area home. Today, Chicago is home to one of the largest urban Indigenous communities in the United States.

With this land acknowledgment, the Roosevelt University community honors, with gratitude, this land and the Indigenous people who have stewarded it throughout the generations. We recognize the Indigenous people who laid the foundation for the city we inhabit, as well as the diverse Indigenous nations that reside here today. We vow to do our part to right the historic wrongs of colonization, to support Indigenous communities' struggles for self-determination, and to be better stewards of the land that we inhabit.

Assessment guidelines

Main forms of assessment

Assignments: Tasks completed outside of class.

- Aims to reinforce learning or explore new topics.
- Assigned weekly, 5-15 points
- Unlimited retakes allowed.
- Teamwork and requesting help is encouraged.

Group Quizzes: Short assessments to test knowledge on recent topics.

- Aims to quickly assess understanding of recent material.
- 20 points, 30 min, individual, taken before class
- Followed by a group quiz during class. Optional.

Exams: Cumulative assessments covering course material.

- Cumulative, mid-term/final.
- 100 points total (50 points/75 minutes each part).
- Completed individually.

Group quiz rules and format

Format of the Quiz

- 20 points total in 20-34 questions
- 1 point for each multiple-choice
- ½ point for each choice in a matching question
- Limited calculations; not testing calculator usage
- Approximately 20-30 minutes for the quiz (time varies by content)
- About 1-1½ minutes per question to prevent collaboration or excessive research
- Not designed to be rushed
- Backtracking allowed (may change if cheating suspected)
- Questions are in random order

Individual Quiz

- Conducted electronically via Blackboard
- Opens 20 hours before the start of class
- Must be completed BEFORE class

Group Quiz

- Form groups of 3-4 students
- Sometimes students pick, sometimes random
- May take a while to organize break out groups
- I try to maintain the same groups if they are working well
- Contact me if there are other students you want in your group
- Collaboration over Zoom Breakout Room/Face-to-Face
- Quiz done electronically over Blackboard
- Same or similar questions to the Individual Quiz
- Only one student per group will submit the group's answers
- The minimum group score is 18 out of 20 points
- Group scores are curved for hard quizzes

Final Score: Average of Individual and Group Scores (e.g., $(14 + 20)/2 = 17$ points)

Remote exam rules

Some class exams will be different from these base rules

Two separate parts of about 50 questions each

- Similar format and questions to the quizzes
- Random question order
- Not all questions will be the same between students
- About 1½ minutes per question to prevent collaboration or excessive research
- Backtracking allowed (subject to change if cheating suspected)

Remote Course Exam Time Period

- Exam review session during class time over Zoom the week of the exam
- Exam opens on Blackboard 1 hour after the in-class review session begins
- 36-hour window to complete both parts of the exam
- Take anytime in the 36-hour window (e.g., the first night for part 2, the second day morning for part 1)
- Each part must be completed in one session
- Clock starts once the part of the exam is open, must finish within the time-limit

Exam submission bonus and penalty policy

Early Exam Completion Bonus:

- Earn +1 extra point by finishing either part of the exam one to two days before the due date.
- Earn an additional point, for a total of +2 points, by completing both parts of the exam in the afternoon on the due date, before the late night deadline.

Late Submission Penalty:

- A penalty of one point for exams completed after the deadline.
- Additional penalties apply for significantly late submissions.

Justification: Your help in meeting the deadline is essential and appreciated. This policy aims to minimize the stress caused by late submissions and logistical issues that may arise.

Make-up exams, quizzes, and assignments

In light of the changing needs of students, particularly highlighted by the experiences during the COVID pandemic, I have adopted a more flexible approach to managing make-up exams, quizzes, and assignments.

Currently, all exams, quizzes, and assignments are conducted or submitted online via Blackboard, each with a specified deadline. I understand that unexpected circumstances may arise, such as illness, personal emergencies, or other significant events, which can make it challenging to meet these deadlines. If you find yourself in a situation that may require an extension, **I encourage you to contact me immediately. I am always open to granting extensions based on individual circumstances.**

Communication is crucial in these situations. I do not need all the details of your situation. However, being informed about your general circumstances is important, as it allows me to offer the necessary support and accommodations. Please reach out as soon as possible if you anticipate needing an extension. Being proactive and communicating is essential and ensures fairness for all students.

The goal of this policy is to create a fair, consistent, and equitable learning environment. It is not designed to penalize you for situations beyond your control. By maintaining open communication and discussing your needs, we can work together to identify the best path forward.

Graded percentage vs total percentage

The **Graded Percentage** shows your score based only on the work that has been graded. It does not include assignments that you have not submitted or items that still need grading. This percentage is useful when the instructor has not yet graded items. It gives you an idea of your current grade, focusing only on the work you have completed and that has been scored.

The **Total Percentage** includes all the items in the grade book, as listed on Blackboard. This includes every assignment, quiz, and exam, regardless of whether they are done, not submitted, or still waiting to be graded. In this percentage, any work that you have unfinished or have not submitted is counted as zero until it is completed and graded. The Total Percentage is more representative when you have assignments that you have not yet attempted. It provides an overview of your performance, factoring in both completed and pending assignments.

In summary, the Total Percentage will be equal to or lower than the Graded Percentage, as it includes unattempted and ungraded assignments. The Graded Percentage is a better measure for students who are up to date with their work, reflecting only graded items. In contrast, the Total Percentage provides a better overview for students with incomplete assignments, as it incorporates all potential grades.

Zoom discussion marks policy

My goal is to create an engaging and interactive learning environment where everyone feels encouraged to participate. Discussion marks are a way to recognize and reward meaningful contributions that enhance learning.

How to Earn Discussion Marks:

- Participate in icebreaker activities at the start of class.
- Engage in the class chat by responding to direct questions during the lecture.
- Provide thoughtful answers to open-ended questions about the material.
- Ask clarifying questions if something is unclear.
- Share personal experiences that relate to the course content.
- Post relevant news articles or resources that connect to the topics we discuss.
- Be on time for the Zoom meeting to earn discussion marks for punctuality.

What Does Not Count:

- Simple acknowledgments like "hi," "thanks," or "yes."
- Answering polls, as it is challenging to assess this data for marks.
- Direct messages during the Zoom session; only contributions to the entire group chat count.

Earn up to 6 discussion marks per three-hour class from active chat participation. These guidelines are designed to encourage meaningful and collaborative engagement in our virtual classroom.

In-person discussion poker chips policy

My goal is to create an engaging and interactive classroom environment where everyone feels encouraged to participate. Discussion marks are a way to recognize and reward meaningful contributions that enhance our collective learning experience.

How to Earn Discussion Marks:

- Participate in icebreaker activities at the start of class.
- Raise your hand and contribute by answering direct questions posed during the lecture.
- Provide thoughtful answers to open-ended questions about the material.
- Ask clarifying questions if something is unclear.
- Share relevant personal experiences that relate to the course content.

- Introduce interesting news articles or resources that connect to the topics we discuss.
- Tracking Participation:
- When you participate meaningfully, you will receive a poker chip. At the end of the lecture, return your poker chips to me to have your discussion marks recorded.

Earn up to 6 discussion marks per 3 hour class by making valuable contributions. These guidelines are designed to foster a meaningful and collaborative learning environment where your contributions can help deepen everyone's understanding of the material.

Common criticisms and my responses to discussion grades

I am fully aware of the drawbacks to this system, but I really want to encourage discussion. Without discussion, you might as well view the lecture on YouTube. There are five main complaints about this system, I am aware that they exist, and I actively try to reduce their impact.

1. **Students ask silly or stupid questions to get marks:** I have to encourage all questions and comments, because otherwise more introverted students might feel discouraged from asking a perceived stupid question.
2. **The instructor favors certain students:** I am aware that I tend to give marks to some students more than others, and I actively try to avoid this through mark shaming (discouraging over-eager students from getting more) and placing limits on the maximum marks, but alas, I am human. I appreciate feedback, so please feel free to report to me any issues of favoritism.
3. **The distribution of marks is inconsistent:** Some great questions go unrewarded while poor questions often get rewarded. Again, I am human; if you feel that you were overlooked and missed a mark (or more), please come up to me after class. I am very forgiving and will likely apologize and reward you for it.
4. **Creates a competitive environment for discussion that is overly stressful:** You should not feel that it is a competition; if you speak only once per week, you can still get a decent grade. Remember, using the cube root ensures that the more marks you get, the less value each additional mark has.

Scoring of discussion grades

During the discussion, I will award discussion marks to students for stimulating discussion, asking thoughtful questions, or correctly answering posed questions. **Discussion marks are not directly equal to points in the grade book.**

At the end of the semester, I will use the fourth-highest discussion mark count as the baseline for 100%. Then, I will apply the cube root to each student's discussion marks ratio to determine their distribution. A person with zero discussion marks will receive a minimal amount of points, and the remaining discussion marks will be scaled up to the maximum points. Using the cube root ensures that as you accumulate more marks, each additional mark has less impact.

There is a limit of 2 discussion marks per hour of the course, so for a 3-hour session, the limit is 6 discussion marks. This rule prevents students from hoarding discussion marks. Discussion marks may also be rewarded for showing up to class on time or staying for the entire class, but this will only apply if attendance becomes a problem.

No make-up for discussion marks

I do not offer make-up opportunities for missed discussion marks. The discussion marks system rewards meaningful participation throughout the semester. Missed opportunities to participate in class discussions cannot be made up later. However, the grading scale accounts for different levels of participation. Consistent engagement throughout the semester is encouraged, but active participation in at least half of the class sessions, or partial participation in all class sessions, still results in a high grade. By rule, more than half of the students in the class will earn an A or A-. This system ensures fairness and highlights the importance of contributing during live class discussions and contributions from all students add to the collective learning experience.

Minor forms of credit (5 points)

Create a Discord account: To encourage communication, I will award 2 credit points for posting a message on Discord anytime during the semester. Please create an account using a web browser or smartphone app. I'll host online office hours and answer questions through Discord.

Student profile: Help me learn your names! You can earn 3 credit points for uploading a picture and answering simple questions about yourself on Google Forms. This profile is due within the first two weeks of class.

Extra credit write-ups (4x 3 points)

Follow this link: <https://docs.google.com/document/d/11xMOcMROjOWdQh8nsDTT1-QAPCGB0tdXihZxVcfEhos/edit>

Grading policies

Grades

Your final grade for this course will be determined by the total points you've earned, compared to the maximum possible points. Percentages will be rounded to a single decimal place. For example, if you earn 500 points out of 715, your percentage would be 69.9%, resulting in a grade of D+. With 501 points out of 715, your percentage would be 70.1%, or a grade of C-. The percentage scale for letter grades is as follows:

Percentage	Grade
92.0% and above	A
90.0-91.9%	A-
88.0-89.9%	B+
82.0-87.9%	B
80.0-81.9%	B-
78.0-79.9%	C+
72.0-77.9%	C
70.0-71.9%	C-
68.0-69.9%	D+
62.0-67.9%	D
60.0-61.9%	D-
Below 60.0%	F

Please note that Roosevelt University enables instructors to send Progress Reports, offering you insights into your performance. These reports may prompt Academic Advisors to connect you with additional support and university resources.

Incomplete grade policy

A grade of incomplete may only be given with the specific consent of the instructor. Proper notification to the Office of the Registrar and the instructor's dean or department chair is also required. A student may only receive an Incomplete grade if:

- The student initiates the request for an incomplete grade before the end of the academic term; and

- The student is in good standing in the course and has completed a majority of the coursework (usually at least 75% of the coursework); and
- A medical condition or other serious, non-academic extenuating circumstance (as documented with the Office of the Dean of Students) prevents them from completing a small portion of the coursework required to complete the course prior to the end of the term; and
- The required work may be reasonably completed in an agreed-upon timeframe with the faculty member (no later than the end of the next semester, excluding summer); and
- The required work does not require the student to retake any portion of the course.

For more information, please see the following website:

<https://catalog.roosevelt.edu/undergraduate/policies/course-and-credit/>

Tuition refund schedule

If you are considering dropping this class, please be aware of the tuition refund schedule below. The amount of tuition refunded depends on when you officially drop the class. You can drop the class online, in person, by fax, or by email.

- 100% Refund: before the first day of week 2
- 50% Refund: before the first day of week 3
- 25% Refund: before the first day of week 4
- 0% Refund: on or after the first day of week 4

For exact dates, please refer to the University Important Dates (spreadsheet) here:

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1YuK02ObBJqxFLQSLx0xtKdaLNBfuOgM466Hh6MRQczE/edit>

Withdrawal from class

The final date for an official withdrawal (drop) from this class (meaning a "W" would appear on your transcript) is **Friday, March 20, 2026**. <https://www.roosevelt.edu/current-students/academics/important-dates>) After that, if you want to withdraw, you'll need to petition the registrar. Petitions are granted only for non-academic reasons after the deadline. If you receive financial aid, it's best to check with your financial aid counselor to assure that aid isn't affected by withdrawing from a class. The complete withdrawal policy is here:

In some cases, your advisor may recommend that you withdraw from a course in which you expect to receive a low grade. This does not happen automatically - students must withdraw officially in the registrar's office. A student who does not withdraw officially from a course may receive a grade of "F" depending on course progress or course attendance, which will become a part of the student's permanent record.

Late withdrawal policy

A student may request an exception to the withdrawal policy by submitting a "*Petition for a Late W Grade*". Exceptions to this policy may be entertained because of **extraordinary non-academic circumstances**. Approval must be received from the instructor of the course, the department chair, and the dean. Students must complete "*Petition for Late Withdrawal*." It must include why they did not withdraw by the deadline and must include documentation.

<https://blogs.roosevelt.edu/student-handbook/student-resources/late-withdrawal/>

Academic integrity

The university's policies on issues such as plagiarism, recycling, cheating and other forms of academic dishonesty can be found in the undergraduate catalog at <http://catalog.roosevelt.edu/undergraduate/policies/academic-integrity-policy/> and the graduate catalog at <http://catalog.roosevelt.edu/graduate/policies/academic-integrity/> Additional guidelines for avoiding plagiarism are available here: <https://www.roosevelt.edu/current-students/academics/academic-integrity> .

Dishonesty of any kind including cheating and plagiarism will not be tolerated. Every semester, I encounter plagiarism and the student says that they did not know it was wrong. If you copy and paste something and turn it in, it is plagiarism. I and the university do not care that you did not know it was wrong, so educate yourself on the meaning of plagiarism and you will be better off.

For combating dishonesty, I use a three-strike system. For the first offense, you earn zero points for that question or section of the assignment and you are reported to the writing center for tutoring. In some rare cases, students will be allowed to re-complete the assignment with reduced points. For the second offense, you earn zero points for the entire assignment. For the third offense, you will earn an F for the course.

All uses of generative artificial intelligence (AI) must adhere to instructors' policies on AI use in their courses. Unauthorized content generation will be considered a violation of RU's academic integrity policy. Students should always confirm with their instructors whether and which AI uses are permitted in each course.

If you have any questions about collaboration with your lab partners and classmates, citations and use of external sources, or any other aspect of academic conduct, ask the instructor. Never assume.

Accommodation policies

Attendance policy

In this course, your consistent presence and timely arrival are not just expected but appreciated. Lectures will begin on time according to the listed schedule, so please make every effort to be present. Although attendance will not be formally tracked, it plays a vital role in your success.

I encourage you to attend all class meetings and discussions, as participation and discussion points are often awarded during these sessions and are unavailable to absent students. Our classroom environment will offer insights and perspectives that may not be heavily covered in the textbook. Missing these unique discussions could put you at a disadvantage in understanding the full scope of the material.

If you foresee an absence, kindly inform me in advance so that we can discuss any potential ways to minimize the impact on your learning.

Should your **attendance fall below two-thirds (2/3) of the class periods**, whether the absences are excused or not, it's crucial that you come and talk to me about your status. Please be aware that with attendance below this threshold, you should not expect to pass the course. I will, of course, be available to discuss your particular situation and see what can be done, but regular attendance is a fundamental requirement for passing.

International students must attend 80% of their courses to maintain their U.S. Visa status.

Lastly, please be aware that attendance reporting is a federal requirement for financial aid during the first two weeks of the semester, so make every effort to attend during that critical period.

Lab attendance and weekly preparation score

Lab attendance is required. Regular attendance in lab class is essential for your success in this course. Labs are hands-on, collaborative, and require an extensive, complex, and unique setup. As a result, make-up labs are not offered. Your attendance and preparation will be assessed weekly.

Deductions may be made for not bringing your lab coat, not wearing lab goggles, having exposed ankles, failing to tie back long hair, or violating other safety rules. Points may also be deducted for not having a copy of the lab manual, not preparing your lab notebook, or arriving late. Additional deductions may apply for failing to lock your drawer, leaving out your drawer key, leaving behind an unclean bench, or any other clean-up issues. Students who are fully prepared, follow safety protocols, and participate actively will earn the full preparation score for that week.

There are no make-up labs, so attending your scheduled session is the only way to earn credit. To balance fairness, accountability, and the reality that illness, emergencies, and conflicts do occur, the following grading system will be used for missed labs:

Absence type	Score	Included in total points
First communicated	N/A	No
Second communicated	3/5	Yes
Third communicated	1/5	Yes
Fourth or higher communicated	0/5	Yes
First <i>uncommunicated</i>	0/5	Yes
Second or higher <i>uncommunicated</i>	-2/5*	Yes

* Negative scores mean points are deducted from the total earned in other weeks.

Absences fall into two categories: communicated and uncommunicated. A **communicated absence** is when a student contacts the instructor before the start of lab to explain they will not be attending. This includes illness, family emergencies, travel conflicts, or personal matters. While communicated absences still result in a reduced or missing preparation score (see table above), they are treated more leniently than absences with no communication. An **uncommunicated absence** is when a student misses lab class without notifying the instructor in advance. These will result in greater point deductions and may impact your standing in the course (see table above).

Accommodation of students with dis/abilities

If you have a condition or disability that requires reasonable accommodation, please alert Disability Services (in the Learning Commons) as soon as possible. To be effective, accommodations should be implemented prior to any assignments, quizzes, or tests. In Chicago, Disability Services is located in the Learning Commons, AUD 1038 (inside the Library), the phone number is 312-341-3629, and the email address for the Disability Services Specialist is nyoon@roosevelt.edu. Staff can offer both in-person and virtual appointments for our students to determine which academic accommodations are feasible and appropriate.

In addition, Disability Services offers an expedited way for students to request accommodations for the first time that bypasses the need to schedule a meeting (unless requested by either party, student or staff). The following is the form that any student can fill out to request accommodations for the first time: https://cm.maxient.com/reportingform.php?RooseveltUniv\&layout_id=20

Disability Services on the Schaumburg campus is located in the Learning Commons, Room SCH 517A. The Learning Support Specialist for Schaumburg is Rebecca Berezin, and you can reach her at rberezin@roosevelt.edu or by phone at 847-619-7978. If you need testing accommodations,

those are also handled through the Learning Commons in Room 517, with regular hours Monday-Friday, 9:00 AM-5:00 PM.

Roosevelt University complies fully with the Americans with Disabilities Act. For more information on Disability Services at Roosevelt, visit this link: [Disability Services Webpage](#).

Religious holidays

Please let your instructor know as soon as possible if you will miss class because you are observing a religious holiday. Roosevelt University policy requires written notification to the instructor within the **first two weeks of the term**. Any work you miss because of a religious holiday can be made up. You can see the full policy by visiting this link:

<https://www.roosevelt.edu/policies>

<https://www.roosevelt.edu/policies/religious-holidays> (PDF file)

Single parents and primary caregivers

As your professor, I recognize the special challenges that single parents and primary caregivers may face. If you have a child or children and unexpected situations might cause delays or interfere with deadlines, please let me know. I will do my best to work with you to make reasonable accommodations. Your success in this class matters to me, and I am here to help you as needed.

Student athletes

Members of NAIA athletic teams who must miss an exam or assignment deadline for regularly scheduled competition, **MUST** present me with an official schedule provided by your coach (with days to be missed identified) during the first two weeks of the semester. If you do not inform me of **your schedule and anticipated absences within the first 2 weeks of the semester**, any absence will be considered unexcused. No absences are allowed for practices.

Conduct and behavioral policies

Classroom conduct

This classroom will be a safe place for all participants. We will treat one another with respect.

Students enrolled in the university are expected to conduct themselves in a manner compatible with the university's function as an educational institution. Please familiarize yourself with the Student Code of Conduct, the Student Handbook and related procedures which is available through this link.

<https://www.roosevelt.edu/current-students/support-services/complaint/conflict-resolution>

Using music devices either in the classroom or in the laboratory is not permitted. Reading materials other than assigned for teaching are not allowed. No children allowed in the classroom. Cellular phones must be set either to the silent/vibration mode or turned off completely before coming into the classroom. Eating or drinking in classrooms is discouraged, but allowed if you do not create a disturbance. Do not bring loud food packaging to class as they will be disruptive. Examples of unacceptable items include, anything that has condiments, fried chicken, french fries, cereal with milk, and salads. Most things from the vending machine are fine. Rude or disruptive behavior will not be tolerated. If you must leave class for any reason, do not distract your classmates. Courtesy and respect are expected of all our students. Any deviation from such an expectation will be a clear violation of the students code of conduct; an act that will neither be tolerated by the instructor nor the department. See also,

<https://www.roosevelt.edu/current-students/support-services/complaint/conflict-resolution>

Title IX and sexual misconduct policy

Roosevelt University cares greatly about the health and wellbeing of our students, staff, faculty, and guests to our campuses. Federal law, specifically Title IX, and the University Sexual Misconduct Policy require that all employees are mandated reporters of incidents involving sexual or gender-based violence or harassment. More information on Title IX at Roosevelt and the complete Sexual Misconduct policy can be found by clicking on this link:

Roosevelt Title IX Web Page: <https://www.roosevelt.edu/title-ix>

The Title IX office will contact any student who discloses an incident regarding student rights, including the option to request an investigation, interim safety measures, and/or academic accommodations. In certain circumstances, the Title IX Coordinator may need to proceed with an investigation, even if none is requested, if there are safety risks to the student or campus community. Participation in the process is voluntary.

Any person may report about sexual or gender-based harassment, sexual assault, dating violence, domestic violence, and/or stalking on or off campus to the Title IX Coordinator titleix@roosevelt.edu. All faculty and staff are Responsible Employees and therefore are mandated to report all instances of sexual misconduct to the Office of Title IX Compliance. Disclosures made to faculty or staff must be forwarded to the Title IX Coordinator at titleix@roosevelt.edu.

If you want a confidential place to disclose sexual assault, sexual harassment or intimate partner violence, there are confidential advisors on campus:

- Toyia K. Stewart, ConfidentialAdvisor@roosevelt.edu, 312-244-0577
- Timely Care MD. <http://www.timelycare.com/Roosevelt>

These professionals are also NOT mandatory reporters and therefore NOT required to report a disclosure to the Title IX Office.

Prohibiting discrimination, harassment, bullying and retaliation

Prohibiting Discrimination, Harassment, Bullying and Retaliation: Roosevelt University is committed to the preservation of the dignity and worth of all members of the University community. To ensure an environment for working and learning in which all individuals are treated with respect, discrimination and harassment are unacceptable and will not be tolerated. In addition, no person who makes a good faith report of discrimination and/or harassment shall be retaliated against in any way. Any person who has a good faith belief that they have experienced or witnessed a violation of Policy must report the incident to the Behavioral Assessment Team at bat@roosevelt.edu.

Rooted in our history and founding, is our belief that each student has the right to attend a university free from discrimination. This includes, but is not limited to, discrimination based on a protected class (i.e. race, sex, age, disability, color, national origin, or religion). If you experience or witness any discriminatory behavior, know that this behavior is the opposite of what we value as an institution and that you can report it.

Incident Reporting Form: https://cm.maxient.com/reportingform.php?RooseveltUniv\&layout_id=0

Challenges to inclusion

The instructor recognizes that the ability for students to comfortably participate in class may be affected by such factors as racial or gender inequality, access to food or housing, and substance abuse. Any student who faces such challenges to their security or access to food or housing is urged to contact the Office of the Dean of Students (<https://www.roosevelt.edu/policies/student-rights/dean-of-students>). Furthermore, if you are comfortable in doing so, please notify the instructor. This will enable the instructor to provide any resources that they may possess.

Expectations

Student expectations

- Regularly check Roosevelt Mail and Blackboard for any updates or important information related to the course.
- Please check your RU email at least once per business day and the day before class meetings to stay updated.
- Visit the Course Blackboard Site three times per week to stay up-to-date with course materials and announcements.
- Expect to spend about 3 hours on coursework and studying for every credit hour of class.
- Review lecture notes regularly to reinforce learning and stay current with the course content.
- Engage with peers through study groups or discussions outside of class to enhance understanding.
- Feel free to use my office hours or email me if you need help or have questions. **I am here to support you.**
- Submit assignments on time to keep pace with the course.
- Assignments are expected to be submitted on time; valid reasons are required for late submissions.

Instructor expectations

- I will plan and prepare thoroughly for all course activities to ensure a structured and productive learning experience.
- I will keep the course moving at a pace that is suitable for the class, ensuring the opportunity to understand the material.
- You will have ample time to complete assignments, projects, and exams, with clear deadlines provided.
- I will be clear and responsive during lectures and labs, making sure that concepts are understandable and questions are addressed.
- I am committed to working with each of you to meet your needs and goals for the course, and I encourage open communication.
- Limited PREVIEW versions of lecture slides will be available on Blackboard before class to help you prepare.
- Full versions of lecture slides will be available on Blackboard within 36 hours after class for your review.
- I will follow the response time listed in [Instructor information](#).
- I will provide feedback on assignments and exams to support your learning and improvement.
- I will promote a respectful and inclusive classroom environment where all students feel valued and heard.

Classroom expectations

- Attend class
- Assume every class is important, and there is no need to ask, "Are we doing anything important today?"
- Lectures will not be repeated privately, but you are welcome to review materials and ask questions.
- Arrive to class on time and come prepared for all course activities and lab exercises.
- Arriving on time and staying for the full class shows respect for the learning process and your classmates.
- Participate actively in discussions to help create a dynamic and engaging class environment.
- Respect the opinions of others during discussions, even when they differ from your own.

Frequently asked questions

What is the difference between an A and an A-?

- An A- grade is earned when your points percentage falls between 90.0% and 91.9%, an A is any grade 92.0% or above.

How are discussion marks earned for remote classes?

- First, Discussion Marks are mostly based on the chat. Not all comments in the chat count, such as "hi", "thanks", or "yes". You can earn up to 6 discussion marks from the chat.
- Second, answering polls does NOT count. It is not easy for me to obtain that data
- Third, being present in the Zoom meeting when class time starts can earn up to 2 discussion marks for being on-time to class.

What should I do if I face a technical issue during a quiz or an exam?

- Document the problem by taking screenshots and noting any errors.
- Contact Dr. Voss immediately via Discord or email.
- Await a response during normal working hours; Dr. Voss will provide solutions such as time extensions or exam resets.

Can I request an extension for assignments or exams?

- Yes, if you experience unexpected circumstances such as illness or personal emergencies, contact Dr. Voss immediately. Extensions are granted based on individual circumstances, with open communication being crucial.

How are group quizzes conducted?

- Group quizzes are formed with 3-4 students, conducted electronically via Blackboard.
- Groups may be self-selected or randomly assigned.
- Only one student per group submits the group's answers.
- The final score is the average of individual and group quiz scores.

How do I contact Dr. Voss?

- See [Instructor information](#) for current contact methods, office hours, and response time.

How does the attendance policy affect my grade?

- Attendance is crucial for success. While not formally tracked, participation points are awarded during class sessions.
- Falling below two-thirds attendance may jeopardize your ability to pass the course. International students must attend 80% of classes to maintain their visa status.

Can I withdraw from the class after the official withdrawal date?

- Late withdrawals are possible by submitting a "Petition for a Late W Grade" due to extraordinary non-academic circumstances, with approval required from the instructor, department chair, and dean.

What is the difference between "Graded Percentage" and "Total Percentage" on Blackboard?

- Graded Percentage only reflects your score on work that has been completed and graded. Total Percentage includes all work in the grade book, counting unattempted or unsubmitted assignments as zero.
- For a full explanation, see the **Graded Percentage vs Total Percentage** section.

Note: this and other syllabus documents are subject to change at any time.

Help and student services

These university services and support contacts are shared by the Fall 2026 courses and are appended once to every complete syllabus download.

Academic advising

Advisors help students review degree options and curriculum requirements for most undergraduate programs; assist undecided students in identifying career goals and academic major; interpret University policies and procedures; and guide students experiencing academic difficulty or academic probation.

Chicago campus: room 1M10, Mezzanine, Wabash Building, (312) 341-4340. Schaumburg campus: SCH 125; (847) 619-7930 Advising@roosevelt.edu

Some students are advised within their college and/or in their individual programs. Graduate students work directly with their academic department. You can schedule an appointment with an academic advisor through the Navigate App or Desktop: <https://www.roosevelt.edu/eab-navigate>

Technology

- The [STUDENT TECHNOLOGY GUIDE](#) on the Roosevelt mobile app is intended to provide you with a quick and easy-to-understand overview of many of the tools and resources provided to help you get things done. Find out about technology essentials, on-campus technology such as computer labs, printing, software, and more.
- Blackboard Support, Training and Quick Guides: The Blackboard course management system is supported by the Academic Technology Solutions staff. A student tutorial is available in the Blackboard Help and Resources for Students section of [Blackboard](#). For additional help, submit a [help desk ticket](#). You may also search the knowledge base for a wide variety of helpful articles.
- Help Desk: The University Help Desk is available to assist with login and other account issues. Open a help ticket on the [IT Help Desk](#).

Campus safety

Chicago Campus: (312) 341-2020 and Schaumburg campus: (847) 619-8989

Career services

The Office of Career Services supports student career readiness through personalized advising, internship search assistance, and job preparation coaching. Our services include resume and

cover letter development, interview practice and preparation, career exploration, skill-building workshops, and graduate school planning. We connect students with employers through career fairs, networking events, and on campus recruitment opportunities. Through Handshake, students have 24/7 access to job and internship listings including on campus employment as well as a wide range of career resources. Appointments can be scheduled via Handshake at roosevelt.joinhandshake.com, or students may contact us by email, phone, or by visiting our office.

Location: 3rd Floor, Wabash Building, WB 324

Phone: (312) 341-3560 Email: career@roosevelt.edu

Counseling services

As we continue to work towards the re-launch of the in-person counseling center, all current students can access several virtual services through the [TimelyCare online platform](#), all of which are no-cost.

TimelyCare offers access to licensed therapists and medical providers through "Talk Now" immediate mental health support, scheduled counseling appointments, psychiatric appointments, health coaching, and on-demand self-care. Their services are available 24/7 and can be accessed anywhere in the US through the Counseling and Wellness webpage or through the TimelyCare app.

Financial aid services

Apply for financial aid, set up payment plans, and answer questions regarding your Roosevelt bill. Chicago campus: Mezzanine, Wabash Building, (866) 421-0935; FAS@roosevelt.edu. Zoom hours are between 10 a.m. and 3 p.m. Monday-Friday. Send an email for a link.

Food and hygiene pantry

The Laker Union Pantry provides free food and hygiene products to students in need. Below are campus-specific details and resources:

- Chicago Campus: The Laker Union Pantry is located in WB309. Students can visit during posted hours or place orders online anytime using the ordering tool available on the [pantry website](#).

Schaumburg Campus: Schaumburg students can access pantry items from the Chicago campus by using the online ordering tool, with the ability to pick-up their order during pantry operational hours. Visit the pantry website for more details (Additional Resources and Support:

- Students seeking connections to additional food and hygiene resources in Chicago or the surrounding suburbs can email HFI@roosevelt.edu for tailored assistance.

- To see if you qualify for SNAP benefits (formerly known as food stamps), use the MRelief eligibility tool linked on the Food and Hygiene Pantry on the Roosevelt Website.

Get Involved: Interested in supporting the pantry? Email lakerunionpantry@roosevelt.edu or head to our website to learn about volunteer opportunities or how to make a donation.

Laker Connect

Laker Connect is the central hub for student involvement at Roosevelt University. You can find, join, and stay connected to student organizations; discover events happening on or near campus; and, track your involvement in various organizations and events. Log into Laker Connect directly [here](#) or access it through [My Roosevelt](#).

Learning commons

The Learning Commons offers tutoring in writing, math, and other subjects; peer mentors; and disability services. Visit our webpage for more information on hours, appointments, and available services: [Learning Commons Website](#)

Tutoring

Chicago campus: In-person and virtual peer tutoring in writing, math, and other subjects is available in the Learning Commons on the Chicago campus. Use Navigate within the Roosevelt app to make an appointment. If you are in need of tutoring, please email learningcommons@roosevelt.edu for assistance.

Students on both the Chicago and Schaumburg campuses have 24/7 access to online tutoring via Brainfuse on Blackboard.

Peer success coaching

In-person and virtual Peer Success Coaching is available in the Learning Commons on both the Chicago and Schaumburg campuses. Use Navigate within the Roosevelt app to make an appointment. If you need help with success coaching, please email learningcommons@roosevelt.edu for assistance.

Disability services

The Learning Commons is also the home of Disability Services. If you have a disability, it is in your interest to register with the Learning Commons. Using our services is private. We aim to teach you the skills you need to be a strong, independent learner, while offering accommodations both in and out of the classroom where necessary.

- Chicago campus: Auditorium Building 1050 (inside the Library), (312) 341-3811.

- Schaumburg campus: room 517A, 847-619-7978.
- Via email: Nicole Yoon nyoon@roosevelt.edu

Laker grant (student emergency fund)

The Laker Grant Fund provides limited financial assistance to currently enrolled Roosevelt University students who need help with immediate, essential expenses because of temporary hardship related to an unforeseen situation. The fund is designated to offset a short-term financial need and is not intended to replace or supplement financial aid. Funds are awarded as a grant, and unlike a loan do not need to be repaid. Funds may count as income and may be subject to federal and/or state taxes. To read more about and to apply for this emergency fund: [Laker Grant Fund Application](#)

Library

Find everything you need to know about the Auditorium Building library, the Schaumburg library, and the Performing Arts library at this link: [Roosevelt Library Website](#).

Name, pronoun, gender change

Roosevelt University will honor a student's request to select a preferred name other than their legal name and/or change their gender designation or pronouns. This policy aligns with the University's commitment to inclusivity on campus. The University reserves the right to reject inappropriate requests such as offensive or derogatory language. You may request a change by filling out this form: [Update Personal Information](#)

Registrar

We are available to answer questions about registration, drop/add, withdrawal, transcripts, credit evaluation, or graduation. Chicago campus: Mezzanine floor, Wabash Building, (312) 341-3535; registrar@roosevelt.edu

Roosevelt mobile app

Download the Roosevelt mobile app, which allows students to easily access many campus services right from your phone, as well as receive important push notifications about registration and other important campus events and news items. The app is available for download for iOS or Android.

Study buddies

Students who participate in study groups tend to develop a deeper understanding of instructional material, and they learn how to think critically and creatively about academic concepts. All Roosevelt students have access to "Study Buddies" through Navigate. Study Buddies is only

available through the mobile app, so you must download the Navigate Student app via the RU app, to your mobile device.

Wi-Fi access

If you are visiting campus for the first time in a while, please note that the process for accessing Wi-Fi on campus has changed to ensure better security. The process will differ based on the device you are using. Please visit the [Tech Support Knowledge Base](#) and review the article outlining the process for your particular device.

Veterans services

Roosevelt recognizes the remarkable contributions made by members of our armed services and the challenges associated with transitioning into a civilian setting. Our student resources reflect this, with support from faculty and staff members who honor the needs of veteran services. If you are a Veteran or Active Service Member, please contact the Office of Veterans Services at ovs@roosevelt.edu.

Student support services STEM

The mission of SSS STEM is to collectively engage, recruit, and retain a cohort of 120 STEM students per year who identify as first-generation and/or low-income and/or have a documented disability to stay on track, achieve academically, persist, and graduate on time by providing holistic, high quality, proactive, and comprehensive supportive services. Through RU's SSS STEM program, students have access to various academic and engagement activities, such as one-on-one academic advising, career and financial workshops, and cultural enrichment opportunities. To learn more about this program, please contact [The RU SSS STEM Office](#).